Sitti Djalia Turabin-Hataman

Sitti Djalia Turabin-Hataman (born November 26, 1977), widely known as **Mayor Dadah**, is a Filipina politician, peace advocate, and human rights activist from Basilan who has built a career out of a single, steady conviction: that good governance and genuine peace can coexist, even in the country's most complex conflict zones.

She currently serves as the **Mayor of Isabela City, Basilan**, a city she's led since 2019 and was re-elected to serve in 2025 under the banner of the **#HAPIsabela** (Happy Isabela) platform.

Before entering electoral politics, she spent years doing the kind of unglamorous, ground-level work that rarely makes headlines: running human rights centers, organizing Moro women in conflict-affected communities, and pushing for spaces where displaced families could feel safe.

Her administration has racked up over **147 awards** in six years, earned Isabela City a place among the **2025 Green Destinations Top 100**, and won the city the **2025 Open and Transparent Local Governance Award**, a recognition that reflects her personal insistence on transparency and accountability.

Turabin-Hataman represents the new face of Bangsamoro leadership: educated, rooted in activism, and deeply committed to bridging the religious and cultural divides that have long shaped Basilan's political landscape.

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Sitti Djalia Turabin-Hataman



Born	November 26, 1977
Place of Birth	Basilan, Philippines
Nickname	Mayor Dadah
Current Position	Mayor of Isabela City, Basilan
Political Career	House of Representatives (2013–2017), Anak Mindanao (AMIN) Party-List
Previous Position	Executive Director, National Commission on Muslim Filipinos (NCMF)
Education	B.S. Biology (WMSU); B.S. Business Economics, M.A. Economics (UP Diliman)
Spouse	Mujiv Hataman
Notable Work	Peacebuilding, women's rights advocacy, inclusive local governance

Early Life and Background

Sitti Djalia Turabin-Hataman was born on November 26, 1977, in Basilan, an island province that sits at the crossroads of Muslim and Christian Mindanao and has historically been one of the more tension-prone areas of the southern Philippines.

Growing up in Basilan shaped her understanding of what governance failures look like up close: communities caught in cycles of conflict, women bearing the heaviest burdens of displacement, and institutions that too often felt absent or inadequate.

That lived experience would become the foundation of everything she did after, from her academic choices to her career trajectory to the kind of mayor she chose to become.

Education

Turabin-Hataman started her university studies at **Western Mindanao State University (WMSU)**, where she pursued a degree in **Biology**.

She later shifted direction toward the social sciences, completing a **Bachelor of Science in Business Economics** at the **University of the Philippines Diliman**.

She followed that with a **Master of Arts in Economics**, also from UP Diliman, giving her both the analytical grounding to understand development policy and the academic credibility to engage with it at a national level.

Career

Grassroots Advocacy

Before she ever ran for office, Turabin-Hataman spent years in the trenches of civil society work.

She served as director of the **Moro Human Rights Center**, an organization focused on documenting abuses and protecting the rights of communities caught in Mindanao's long-running conflict.

She also served as president of **Pinay Kilos (PINK)**, a women's organization dedicated to empowering Moro women in conflict-affected areas of Mindanao. The work wasn't glamorous, but it was formative, and it built the networks and credibility she'd rely on throughout her public life.

Executive Director, NCMF

In 2010, she made her first formal entry into government when she was appointed as the **Executive Director of the National Commission on Muslim Filipinos (NCMF)**.

The role placed her at the center of national policy conversations around Muslim Filipino identity, rights, and welfare, and it marked a clear transition from community-based organizing to institutional leadership.

House of Representatives (2013–2017)

From 2013 to 2017, she served as a party-list representative for **Anak Mindanao (AMIN)** in the House of Representatives.

During her tenure in Congress, she was a consistent advocate for women's rights, children's welfare, and the broader interests of the Bangsamoro people. She pushed for legislation on child-friendly evacuation spaces, an issue that speaks directly to the experience of displaced families in conflict zones.

In October 2017, she made the unusual decision to resign from her congressional seat to return to community-based work, a move that reinforced her reputation as someone more interested in impact than in holding office for its own sake.

Mayor of Isabela City (2019–Present)

She was elected Mayor of Isabela City in 2019 and re-elected in the **May 2025 elections** for what is her final term.

Her administration operates under the **#HAPIsabela** platform, a governance vision centered on happiness, accountability, and progress for all communities in the city.

Isabela City is a religiously and culturally diverse place, with a predominantly Christian population alongside significant Muslim and Indigenous communities. Turabin-Hataman has made inclusive leadership central to how she governs, consistently working to bridge divides rather than exploit them.

Under her watch, the city institutionalized **Freedom of Information (FOI)** at the local level, a significant governance reform that reflects her administration's commitment to transparency.

Institutional Contributions

Turabin-Hataman's contributions go well beyond her formal roles in government.

Her years leading the Moro Human Rights Center helped establish a more systematic approach to documenting and addressing human rights concerns in Basilan and the broader Bangsamoro region.

Her work with Pinay Kilos (PINK) helped formalize structures for women's organizing in conflict-affected communities, building a model for civil society engagement that others could follow.

At the national level, her time with the NCMF allowed her to help shape how the Philippine government engages with Muslim Filipinos on matters of identity, faith, and welfare.

As mayor, she's helped position Isabela City as a model for transparent, accountable local governance, particularly through the institutionalization of FOI, which earned the city the **2025 Open and Transparent Local Governance Award** from the national government.

Legacy

It's still early to write a final verdict on Sitti Djalia Turabin-Hataman's legacy, but the contours are already clear.

She represents a generation of Bangsamoro leaders who came up through civil society, who understand conflict from the inside, and who've chosen governance as a tool for peace rather than a platform for personal advancement.

Her signature contribution may well be proving that a city like Isabela, with all its demographic complexity and historical tension, can be governed with transparency, cultural sensitivity, and genuine care for all its residents.

The **#HAPIsabela** vision isn't just a tagline. It's a governance philosophy rooted in the belief that happiness, in the most practical sense, comes from institutions that work, communities that feel safe, and leaders who show up.

The over 147 awards her administration has earned are not just trophies. They're evidence that what she's been trying to build in Isabela City is real.

Awards and Recognition

- **The Outstanding Women in the Nation's Service (TOWNS)** awardee, October 2025, recognized for transformative work in peacebuilding and socio-economic development
- **2025 Open and Transparent Local Governance Award**, for institutionalizing Freedom of Information at the local level
- **2025 Green Destinations Top 100 Stories**, for sustainable tourism initiatives involving Indigenous Sama Bajau women
- Multiple **Seal of Good Local Governance (SGLG)** citations
- Over **147 awards** across six years of mayoral service

Challenges

Governing Isabela City has never been a simple task.

Basilan has long been associated with armed conflict, and the city's demographic diversity, while a source of strength in the right hands, can also be a source of tension if not managed carefully.

Turabin-Hataman has had to navigate the complex religious and cultural dynamics between the city's Christian majority and its Muslim and Indigenous communities, all while keeping the peace process on track and delivering basic services.

Her decision to resign from Congress in 2017 was itself a signal that she understood the limits of what national-level work could accomplish, and that real change in places like Basilan has to be built from the ground up.

Personal Life

Sitti Djalia Turabin-Hataman is married to **Mujiv Hataman**, the former governor of the Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (ARMM) and currently a Representative of Basilan.

They have children, including **Ahmed Djaliv Amin Hataman**, who serves as a Board Member and is active in local governance in Basilan.

See Also

- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM)
- Mujiv Hataman
- Anak Mindanao (AMIN) Party-List
- National Commission on Muslim Filipinos (NCMF)
- Isabela City, Basilan

External Links

- Official Website of Isabela City (https://isabelacity.gov.ph/)
- Wikipedia: Sitti Djalia Hataman (https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Sitti_Djalia_Hataman)

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